CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

TRANSLATOR / INTERPRETER IN THE AI ERA

The machine translates the words. It still can't stand in the room, read the faces, and carry the meaning.

★ TL;DR — NO — to generalist translation as the plan. The median is ~$60K (BLS $60,170), but the per-word freelance market underneath it is collapsing into machine-translation post-editing: BLS cut this occupation's growth outlook from +42% to +2%, and the median barely moved last year. Certified niches survive; the roadmap below is the way OUT of the generalist trap, not in. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

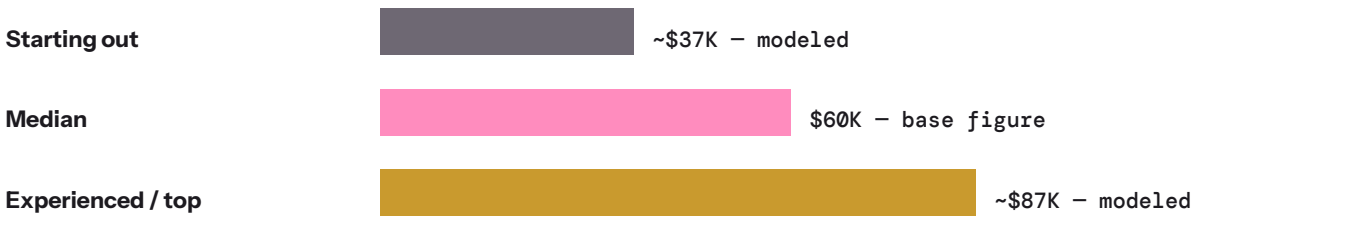
OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$60K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK HIGH · CERTIFICATE

- Fails as a start because: written translation — the volume work that fed beginners — is instant, cheap and good enough for most buyers; BLS now describes the standard job as post-editing machine output.
- The money problem: a ~$60K median that rose +0.4% in a year — a pay cut after inflation — with per-word rates collapsing as clients post-edit machine output instead of hiring translators.
- Still worth money: true bilingual judgment — nuance, register, culture, and being trusted in a live room. That sells in law, training and care settings.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Translator / Interpreter is a ~$60K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state,

employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A TRANSLATOR / INTERPRETER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Translate documents while preserving meaning, tone and formatting
- ✓ Interpret live conversations: clinics, courts, business calls, conferences
- ✓ Localize content so it reads native, not converted
- ✓ Proofread and fix machine or junior translations

Think: a ferryman after the bridge opened — most traffic drives over; what remains is guiding people where there's no bridge.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Document translation at scale, subtitles, first-pass localization, glossaries — machine translation is instant and, for plain text, honestly good.	Live nuance: irony, fear, diplomacy, a witness choosing words, a patient describing pain. Meaning under pressure, with a human accountable for it.

⚠ **THE PER-WORD TRAP: rates are quoted per word while the buyer compares you to a tool that's free per word. Any plan priced by volume is already over.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Language as craft: nuance, culture, precision ✓ Live interpreting is varied, human and genuinely needed ✓ Remote-friendly for the written side	✗ Not volume-safe: the document pipeline is automated end to end ✗ Not rising: a ~$60K median that barely moved last year, with the freelance rate slide underneath it ✗ Not beginner-fed: agencies give the surviving work to certified veterans

Good fit? Certified interpreters in legal and medical settings where a license and liability keep humans mandatory — narrow, real, and defensible.
Bad fit? Beginners whose asset is 'I speak two languages.' So does the phone in your client's pocket — the plan must be built on what the phone can't do.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Corporate Trainer	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Paralegal

A $69,280 median with +11% growth (BLS, Training and Development Specialists) — the strongest verified door out of language work, built on live-room skill: companies pay humans to train global teams across language and culture — presence, reading the room, and judgment that no recording replicates. Your interpreting years are delivery reps nobody else has. First move: build one 60-minute cross-cultural session for a company type you know and pitch it to one HR contact.	A $62,890 median (BLS) — honest framing: growth is 0% and BLS says AI will limit paralegal demand too. What this door actually sells is volume and your premium: ~40,800 replacement openings a year, and law firms serving immigrant and international clients pay for someone who reads both the language and the paperwork. First move: translate one legal document perfectly and write up the traps you caught — that's the interview story.

Smart move: If you're already in: specialize where error has a price — legal, medical, compliance — and get the certification that makes you the required human, not the optional one.
Where you land after: You land where your two languages come with a second profession attached — the training room or law — so the language multiplies pay instead of competing with free.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
PRICE THE	CHOOSE THE	LEARN THE	BUILD THE	ENTER THROUGH	ATTACH THE

STEP 1 — Price the words honestly

FREE · TODAY

- List your services; mark everything a free tool now delivers
- Your survivors: live rooms, liability, nuance — build there

STEP 2 — Choose the second profession

FREE · 1 WEEK

- Corporate training vs paralegal — pick by the rooms you already know
- Your languages become the multiplier, not the product

STEP 3 — Learn the training/legal core

SELF-PACED · 4–8 WEEKS

- Instructional design basics or paralegal foundations
- Study with your bilingual edge in view: every concept, two markets

STEP 4 — Build the proof artifact

FREE · 2 WEEKS

- One flawless legal translation with traps annotated — or one training session, delivered once
- Capture feedback in writing; testimony is your new rate card

STEP 5 — Enter through the bilingual door

FREE · ONGOING

- Apply where postings mention your language pair — those seats have thin competition
- Pitch firms and companies serving clients in your second language

STEP 6 — Attach the credential

ONGOING

- Line up the training credential or paralegal certificate that locks the pivot
- Raise the rate: you're bilingual AND credentialed now

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: mark every service a free tool covers. Your plan lives in what's left.

□ Days 1–30: pick the lane — training or legal; start the core study; draft the proof artifact.

□ Days 31–60: finish the artifact; deliver the session or the sample; collect written feedback.

□ Days 61–90: applications aimed at bilingual postings; credential enrollment done.

□ Day 90: you're a bilingual specialist with a second trade — not a per-word vendor racing a free tool.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **SELL THE ROOM, NOT THE WORDS** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.